

“I’m not saying we won’t get our hair mussed. But I do say no more than ten to twenty million killed, tops.”

General Turgidson / Dr. Strangelove

between Washington and Moscow had been set up in 1963, and Kubrick’s movie nudged the concept toward its logical conclusion: a Cold War reduced to the vying for dominance of two men’s wounded egos. “Of course it’s a friendly call,” Muffley pouts into the receiver, “if it wasn’t friendly then you probably wouldn’t even have gotten it.” These jokes must have chilled the blood of contemporary viewers, and they still unnerve today.

A less sophisticated spat occurs later in the movie, between the gum-chewing General “Buck” Turgidson (George C. Scott) and the Russian ambassador (Peter Bull): the Cold War reduced even further, to a schoolboy scuffle. “Gentlemen,

you can’t fight in here,” says a horrified Muffley, “This is the War Room!” It is silly, clever, and, deep down, full of rage. Kubrick clearly hated these characters; the men in *Dr. Strangelove* are a bunch of clowns, pathetic and deluded, and the director originally intended to end his movie with an epic cream-pie battle. He filmed the sequence, then changed his mind, and swapped the pies for nuclear warheads, in case anyone thought these clowns might be harmless. ■

The poster for the movie shows the presidents of the two most powerful countries in the world, who squabble over the telephone like children. They are powerless to prevent the nuclear catastrophe.



Stanley Kubrick
Director

Born in New York in 1928, Kubrick spent his early years as a photographer and a chess hustler. These two interests—images and logic—would inform his career as a movie director, which began in 1953 with *Fear and Desire*. Kubrick cast his analytical eye over several genres—historical epic (*Spartacus*), comedy (*Dr. Strangelove*), science fiction (*2001: A Space Odyssey*), period drama (*Barry Lyndon*), horror (*The Shining*)—giving them a unifying theme of human frailty. He was perhaps less interested in humans than he was in machines, not just the hardware of cinema but also society’s obsession with technological progress. His unrealized final project, the science-fiction epic *A.I. Artificial Intelligence*, would have offered his last word on this subject. It was filmed by Steven Spielberg in 2001, two years after Kubrick’s death.

Key movies

1964 *Dr. Strangelove*
1968 *2001: A Space Odyssey*
1971 *A Clockwork Orange*
1980 *The Shining*

